Research: Quayola and the Strata Series

ARTIST RESEARCH · LMC 3402 · GENERATIVE ART

Your initial research captures three fundamental aspects of Quayola's work: the relationship between classical figuration and abstraction, the use of historical iconography, and computational stratification.

I've expanded that research using interviews with Quayola, descriptions published by his studio, and exhibition materials. The most important discoveries concern why he transforms images, how much artistic control he retains, and what the resulting abstractions are intended to reveal.

1. Artistic philosophy: Looking beyond representation

Separating an image from its meaning

One of the central ideas behind Strata is that an artwork can be understood independently of what it depicts.

Classical paintings often contain religious, historical, or mythological narratives. For example, a Baroque painting depicting Christ's crucifixion is typically appreciated through its religious symbolism, historical significance, and technical craftsmanship.

Quayola is interested in something different: what happens when we disregard the recognizable subject and examine the painting as an arrangement of colors, shapes, proportions, and spatial relationships?

An especially revealing explanation appears in his February 2025 interview with The Overview.

Quayola describes an exercise from his traditional art education in Rome. Students were asked to analyze classical paintings without referring to the stories they depicted. His teachers sometimes even had students turn paintings upside down, making it easier to focus on visual composition rather than recognizable imagery.

He later applied this same approach using computational technology.

The Overview+1

Why this is significant: His process is not simply about turning a realistic image into an abstract one. It is about changing the method through which we observe and interpret a familiar image.

Abstraction as a form of investigation

In a 2016 interview with The Berliner, Quayola explains that he uses computer vision to investigate individual characteristics of classical paintings, comparing the process to studying an image through a medical scan.

He also emphasizes that the original paintings' stories often become almost impossible to recognize in the resulting work. That disappearance is intentional.

His objective is to create an entirely new object of contemplation from the visual information contained within the original.

The Berliner

This suggests an important distinction:

- Conventional abstraction: An artist simplifies or transforms recognizable subjects into abstract forms.
- Quayola's approach: An artist establishes a computational process for investigating the underlying visual relationships of an existing subject, allowing a new abstract composition to emerge.

This is a useful distinction to articulate in your research because it shifts the emphasis from an abstract visual style to an exploratory artistic method.

2. The concept of Strata: Archaeology, time, and transformation

Your notes already identify stratification as a central technique. However, the meaning of the term goes beyond the literal layering of visual elements.

In geology, strata are layers of material deposited during different periods. They preserve traces of the past while simultaneously becoming part of newer formations.

Quayola uses this concept as a metaphor for the accumulation of artistic languages and historical periods. A centuries-old painting is analyzed through contemporary software, producing an image in which historical and digital aesthetics coexist.

A description of the series published in the bitforms gallery catalog connects stratification with the idea that history accumulates through layers rather than progressing as a simple linear sequence.

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Three interpretations emerge from this concept:

Historical layering. The source artwork preserves the compositional decisions of an earlier artist, while the computational transformation introduces a contemporary aesthetic language.

Visual excavation. The algorithm acts as an instrument for uncovering relationships that are difficult to distinguish within the complexity of the original image.

Simultaneous destruction and construction. The original subject becomes fragmented, but its visual information contributes to the creation of an entirely new composition.

Quayola is therefore not necessarily attempting to improve, restore, or criticize the original artwork. In a 2011 Design Week interview, he characterized the installations as a celebration of art that encourages viewers to experience familiar images differently.

Design Week

This is particularly important when thinking about Strata as a transformation rather than a replacement of its source material.

3. Specific works: How the Strata series developed

Looking at the individual works reveals how Quayola applies a consistent conceptual approach to different types of historical imagery.

Quayola | Strata #1 (2008) | Artsy

Strata #1 (2008)

Baroque ceiling fresco, Rome

Strata #2 - QUAYOLA

Strata #2 (2008)

Gothic stained glass, Paris

Quayola | Strata #3 (2009) | Artsy

Strata #3 (2009)

Neoclassical theater ceiling, Bordeaux

Strata #4 - QUAYOLA

Strata #4 (2011)

Flemish Baroque painting, Lille

Strata #1 — The complexity of Baroque composition

Strata #1 reinterprets the ceiling frescoes of the Church of the Gesù in Rome, including Giovanni Battista Gaulli's Triumph of the Name of Jesus.

Baroque ceiling frescoes often create the illusion that architecture opens toward an infinite heavenly space. Figures, clouds, and painted architectural details merge into complicated compositions.

Quayola reinterprets these relationships computationally, producing abstract formations from the fresco's existing formal characteristics.

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A notable aspect is how an image that already creates the illusion of three-dimensional depth becomes the source material for a new, artificial spatial construction.

Strata #2 — Geometry already embedded in Gothic art

Strata #2 analyzes stained-glass windows from Notre-Dame and Saint-Eustache in Paris.

Unlike figurative painting, stained glass already divides its imagery into distinct colored regions separated by structural boundaries.

Its geometry therefore has a direct relationship to computational segmentation: existing shapes and colors are reinterpreted as independent elements in an evolving abstract composition.

QUAYOLA

This is an example of Quayola identifying a latent structural characteristic of an artwork and making it the primary visual subject.

Strata #3 — From architectural ornament to digital fragmentation

Strata #3 examines the Neoclassical ceiling frescoes of the Grand Théâtre de Bordeaux.

Its compositions introduce moving geometric formations into an architectural setting dominated by symmetry, painted figures, and ornamental organization.

The viewer moves between recognizing the original composition and observing an increasingly autonomous geometric structure.

QUAYOLA

Strata #4 — The relationship between figuration and geometry

Strata #4 is especially relevant to your research because of its pronounced use of polygonal abstraction.

It analyzes four monumental altarpieces from the Palais des Beaux-Arts in Lille, including paintings by Peter Paul Rubens and Anthony van Dyck.

The source works include Rubens' Martyrdom of St. Catherine, The Ecstasy of Mary Magdalene, and The Descent from the Cross, as well as Van Dyck's Christ on the Cross.

Rather than producing a simple geometric copy, the installation transforms the paintings' visual characteristics into shifting polygonal structures that alternately retain and obscure recognizable forms.

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For closer study, there is a full 10-minute video of Strata #4 provided by the artist and bitforms gallery.

4. Technique: Computational analysis and geometric transformation

Your research identifies triangulation and the conversion of color information into three-dimensional landscapes. Here is a more detailed picture of the technique, based on published descriptions.

Historical source imagery

Paintings, frescoes, stained-glass windows, and architectural features provide the underlying visual material.

Computational analysis

Custom software examines properties such as color, proportions, shapes, lines, and composition.

Geometric reconstruction

The extracted information generates meshes, polygons, and other abstract spatial structures.

Artistic calibration

Quayola adjusts the system's rules and parameters, determining the nature and degree of abstraction.

Time-based composition

The evolving results are presented through animation, installations, prints, or other media.

Conceptual reconstruction of Quayola's documented practice, not a verified step-by-step description of his proprietary software.
Design Week+2

Triangulation as an artistic technique

An important additional technical term is Delaunay triangulation, explicitly associated with Strata #4 in a 2011 article by The Creators Project.

vice

This computational geometry technique connects a collection of points to create a network of triangles. The generated network can be used to represent the structure of an image as a geometric mesh.

With image-derived triangulation, an artist can control how finely the source image is subdivided and how recognizable its original details remain.

Your existing source from PRINT Magazine describes an additional technique: using the color temperature of the triangles to determine their elevation, converting areas of an image into a topographic surface.

PRINT Magazine

That detail is valuable, but it is important to distinguish a published description of the early Strata process from a confirmed rule governing every work in the series.

The precise sampling methods, mathematical mappings, and settings used throughout Quayola's proprietary software are not fully documented in the sources I found.

Why three-dimensionality matters

One especially interesting feature of Strata is how Quayola treats a two-dimensional painting as though it contains an underlying spatial landscape.

The painting is no longer simply a flat picture. Its colors and geometric properties become information that can generate spatial formations.

This introduces a new relationship between painting and sculpture: an image originally created through brushstrokes becomes something that resembles a sculptural object assembled from polygons.

The work can therefore shift between image, surface, architectural space, and virtual sculpture without entirely abandoning its source.

5. The artist's role: Generative does not mean fully automated

One of the most important findings from these interviews is that Quayola's works are not simply produced by an algorithm operating independently.

In his 2023 interview with Art Plugged, Quayola describes his custom software as similar to a musical instrument. The system has generative capabilities, but it requires a human artist to calibrate, direct, and perform with it.

He also explains that the technology can suggest unexpected possibilities, making it something closer to a collaborator than a passive tool.

Art Plugged

This introduces a distinction between algorithmic autonomy and artistic authorship.

The computer performs operations and generates new visual structures, but Quayola retains responsibility for determining the original subject, selecting meaningful properties to investigate, controlling parameters, and deciding which outcomes have artistic value.

An algorithm can produce thousands of technically valid compositions, but those compositions do not necessarily share the aesthetic or conceptual intentions of the artist.

This is particularly relevant to your assignment because your slides emphasize that the artist defines the rules and curates the results even when an AI agent writes much of the code.

6. The process itself can be the artwork

Another valuable source is art critic Domenico Quaranta's 2017 essay, Images In and Beyond Time: On Quayola's Laocoöns.

Quaranta examines how Quayola's work challenges the traditional understanding of an artwork as a permanent, finished object.

Instead, he interprets Quayola's practice as an ongoing process driven by rules, parameters, and changing relationships between digital and physical forms.

According to Quaranta, video, prints, and sculpture can function as manifestations of that underlying generative process. The artist selects the moments and media that best communicate its qualities.

domenicoquaranta.com

This interpretation is especially relevant to Strata. The shifting animation is not simply a decorative effect applied to an abstract painting. The transformation over time is an essential part of how the work communicates its concept.

Another useful point from Quaranta's essay is that Quayola often investigates selected fragments of original artworks rather than treating entire compositions as indivisible images. Such fragments can become almost unrecognizable while still preserving qualities of the historical source.

7. Related work: Iconographies and Topologies

Two related projects are worth studying alongside Strata, without confusing their specific techniques.

Quayola | Iconographies #20-13 (2014) | Artsy

Iconographies

This later series uses computer vision to investigate Renaissance and Baroque paintings, generating abstract compositions realized in prints, engravings, and other forms. In some works, the geometric transformation creates the appearance of a historical painting deteriorating or being excavated.

The Berliner+1
ofBook - Basics of Generating Meshes from an Image

Topologies (2010)

This installation computationally reinterprets Velázquez's Las Meninas and Tiepolo's The Immaculate Conception using complex triangulated structures. Its extensive networks of points and lines provide a particularly relevant precedent for thinking about geometry as an expressive visual language.

bitforms gallery

8. Main research conclusions

The strongest overarching interpretation is that Quayola uses generative systems as an alternative way of observing an existing artwork, rather than merely as a tool for applying a new visual style.

His work involves three intersecting ideas: studying a subject through its formal characteristics rather than its symbolic meaning; translating those characteristics into an independent computational language; and using the resulting transformation to create a dialogue between historical and contemporary aesthetics.

One subtle distinction is worth preserving in your written analysis: Quayola frequently describes his work in terms of universal beauty and perfection, but the algorithms themselves do not objectively prove that those universal principles exist. His choices about what to analyze, emphasize, and preserve are still artistic judgments.

For your particular assignment, the most relevant precedent is how he creates related works across different media. Your slides require a single generative system capable of producing both a moving, full-color 4K presentation and an A3 pen-plotter output composed of strokes. Quayola's 2012 Strata exhibition similarly brought video installations together with drawings related to his geometric processes.

bitforms gallery

That gives you a strong conceptual foundation without requiring you to reproduce the exact appearance or technical procedures of his work.

Recommended sources for your research notes

These are the sources I would prioritize beyond those already included in your PDF.

Davide Quayola: Engaging with History

The Berliner · 2016 · Artist interview

Probably the most useful source for understanding his hands-on computational process, formal analysis, and the removal of historical narratives.

Technology Moves Fast, but Art Takes Time

The Overview · 2025 · Artist interview

Particularly useful for understanding his educational background, the importance of observing paintings differently, and the relationship between classical and computational art.

Strata #4 by Quayola

The Creators Project · 2011 · Artwork feature

Valuable for its discussion of the geometric transformation process, including Delaunay triangulation and installation scale.

Interview with Quayola

LISA · 2011 · Artist interview

Explains how Quayola thinks about creating artistic systems, defining aesthetic guidelines, and using technology across multiple mediums.

Images In and Beyond Time: On Quayola's Laocoöns

Domenico Quaranta · 2017 · Critical essay (PDF)

Stronger for theoretical research: the generative process as artwork, relationships between time and material, and archaeological interpretations of digital imagery.

For your next stage, I would especially preserve the distinction between an algorithm that produces a particular visual effect and an algorithm that investigates the qualities of a chosen subject. That distinction is arguably the most important part of Quayola's Strata philosophy, and it gives you a way to develop an original iconographic work rather than simply imitate his geometric aesthetics.